DEALING WITH THE LADY: THE MILITARY STRUGGLE WITH AUNG SAN SUU KYI

Following the electoral fiasco, the junta had to find a way to effectively deal with Aung San Suu Kyi. It had always been stated to Suu Kyi that she could leave anytime to visit her husband and children with a clear understanding that she would never be allowed to return to Myanmar. On numerous occasions she had demanded to be treated like all other political prisoners and requested to be sent to the infamous Insein prison. The military instead opted to keep her under house arrest for most of her detention. Suu Kyi decided to go on a hunger strike in protest. After a period of 12 days and persistent pressure from her husband Michael Aris, Suu Kyi relented and ended the strike. After her family's departure in September 1989, all of their passports were revoked. Her husband would be allowed periodic visits, but the military was hoping that she would give up the fight and return to her family at some point in time.

As the pressure mounted on the NLD and Suu Kyi, the military also lashed out against the sangha. Over 300 monasteries were raided as the military regime decided to tighten the control over the Buddhist organizations within Myanmar. While incarcerated, Suu Kyi became devoted to strengthening her Buddhist faith. Her daily routine of meditation and memorizing the sutras gave her the inner strength to continue the fight.

Throughout her imprisonment, Suu Kyi was honored and her struggle was highly publicized. During the past 25 years she has received over 20 humanitarian awards. In 1991, she was awarded the Sakharov Prize for Freedom of Thought and later the announcement of the Nobel Peace Prize was made. This was a remarkable feat for someone who was involved in a political struggle for only a few brief years. Her sons Alex and Kim accepted it on her behalf in December 1991. The Nobel Prize was a mixed blessing for Aung San Suu Kyi. Demonstrations were organized on her behalf and an enormous amount of media attention was leveled in her direction. Suu Kyi was now a celebrity with Hollywood movies such as *Beyond Rangoon* and The Lady detailing her plight. The negative side was that the attention she received was looked upon in a critical fashion by the ruling junta. Many experts believed that the regime took an even harder stance in dealing with protesters and dissidents in order not to be perceived